

The Best Places to Eat Okonomiyaki

Dotonbori Street inexpensive

The search for fantastic *okonomiyaki* pulls everyone, inevitably, back to the Vegas-on-the-cheap glitz of Dotonbori – because this ceaselessly busy restaurant strip is its spiritual home. You'll find many of Osaka's 4,000 or so *okonomiyaki* restaurants here, most of them featuring a bewildering array of plastic models of *okonomiyaki* in their window to help you choose your variety of topping. In most places you'll be given a bowl of batter and some ingredients so you can make up your own mix. You then pour it on to a hotplate built into your table, flip the resulting thick disk with a metal spatula when one side is cooked, and finally divide it into pizza-style slices with the same spatula (the serving staff are usually happy to help *okonomiyaki* novices, of course). Brush with sauce, squirt with Japanese mayo, and sprinkle with nori, *katsubushi*, *kimchi*, or whatever takes your fancy.

Dotonbori, Osaka; some restaurants open 24/7

Also in Osaka

For a more refined take on the meal-in-one miracle that is *okonomiyaki*, head for the rather more dressy **President Chibo (+81 6 6212 2211; moderate)**, also on Dotonbori. This five-floor temple to *okonomiyaki* opened in 1967 with the aim of taking the dish upmarket – hence the low lighting, marble counters, and chefs dressed in the French style. The *okonomiyaki* here are superlative, but purists might argue that having a chef cook them for you with tinkly music and attentive waiters is rather like having a *haute cuisine* hot dog.

Also in Japan

Both Tokyo and Hiroshima claim to have devised the ultimate incarnation of *okonomiyaki*. On **Monja Street (inexpensive)** in Tokyo's Tsukishima district you can try the local version, called *monjayaki*, which has the same basic ingredients as the Osakan version but is much runnier and doesn't shape up into quite such a pleasing patty. In Hiroshima, rather than mixing everything together, they prefer to layer their ingredients, sometimes adding *natto* (fermented soybean) or, more happily, a delicious, plump Hiroshima oyster. Try it in **Okonomi Village (inexpensive)**, a futuristic building with three floors of *Hiroshima-yaki* (rather than *okonomi-yaki*) eateries.



Above *Okonomiyaki* has been described as a Japanese pancake, omelet, or tortilla – it's a complete meal in a handy carry-out package

Left A cook at a food stand on Dotonbori demonstrates speed and skill, frying and flipping *okonomiyaki* to perfection